geopolitical prowess guarantees it a global presence higher in profile than what its economic capacity would normally reflect. Russia retains, as the inheritor state of the USSR, a seat at the international table more by virtue of its diplomatic assets (veto power at the UN Security Council and nuclear weapons) than by economic prowess. And yet this international clout remains key. The Kremlin's overall foreign goal is thus a double and mutually reinforcing one: to integrate into the global economy, on the one hand, but to do so on its own terms, attempting a restoration of its 'great power' status in the system from which to try and build a new 'concert of powers' and a stable multipolar world. Russia seeks to become a global player, safe from the vicissitudes of Pax Americana and solid in its acknowledged role as regional hegemon. The international aspirations of Russian capitalism, therefore, appear contradictory and, in its difficulties, potentially dangerous. Additionally, the relative weaknesses of a state which challenged the US during much of the 20th century, which has seen bouts of impressive industrial development and which can boast an intensely skilled and educated population to take it forward, appear clearly as the results of political choices, elite projects imposed over the last two decades after the collapse of the USSR. The Russian political economy today in part responds to a design, shared unevenly between international and domestic actors. What then, in broad strokes, is the class nature of Russian neoliberalism, and how does it condition Moscow's international behaviour?

Neoliberal imperialism à la Russe

There is a story which, aside from illustrating the different spatial manifestations of Russian neoliberalism, captures quite well the basic contours of the Putin regime. In September 2005, Gazprom consolidated its position as a global energy behemoth (and Russia's largest firm) with the purchase of a 72.6% stake in the oil company Sibneft, at the time part of a holding company (Millhouse Capital) owned by Roman Abramovich. The operation marked the largest corporate takeover in Russia's history, even when the agreed price had only reached US$13 billion. On the day of this historic garage-sale, however, Sibneft's market value was approximately ten times that amount: if Sibneft had been sold in an international tender it would have gone at a much higher price. The takeover was followed by some important changes: Sibneft would now act as Gazprom's oil branch, and was duly renamed Gazprom Neft (Upstreamonline 2005). The new firm, hitherto based in Moscow, was quickly registered in St Petersburg. In November that year, Gazprom's CEO, Alexei Miller, accompanied by the governor of St Petersburg, Valentina Matviyenko, currently speaker of Russia's